Swaraj, appeared to back Advani. At the Goa meeting, Swaraj had suggested that any announcement on Modi as campaign chief be deferred because Advani was not present. She was overruled. Swaraj always saw Modi as authoritarian even as she had abiding affection for Advani. She also knew her great rival, Jaitley, was close to Modi and was worried the duo were plotting to marginalize her. Veteran leader Jaswant Singh, who had already been isolated within the party, also decided to stay away from the executive. But apart from the handful of veterans, the majority of the party was firmly with Modi.

A worried Rajnath Singh consulted the RSS top brass in Nagpur who advised him to stick to the original decision on Modi. But the Sangh leadership was also keen that he broker a truce with Advani. Gadkari, who enjoyed the full trust of the RSS, was assigned the task. The Nagpur-based leader kept shuttling between Advani and Rajnath Singh's residences. 'I lost a few kilos in the process,' he joked later. Modi called up Advani as well, and said he remained his 'guiding force'. Jaitley met Advani for two hours and told him that as the man who had built the modern-day BJP, his newfound image as a dissident was only doing him harm. After forty-eight hours of a family soap-like political drama, Advani had little choice but to take back his resignation.

So, why did the eighty-five-year-old Advani attempt to stall Modi's ascent? Critics suggest that the elderly leader had been driven by undiluted personal ambition, and that his family in particular was keen that he remain in the prime ministerial picture. 'Advani had not got over the disappointment of 2009 and could not accept the fact that the party had now moved onto a new leadership as represented by Modi,' says a BJP commentator. When a former political aide of Advani, Sudheendra Kulkarni, went on television calling Modi a 'dictator', it only seemed to confirm the belief that the Advani 'camp' had been spoiling for a fight. Kulkarni, though, denies drafting Advani's letter of resignation.

Advani's supporters say his actions were propelled by nothing more than a genuine concern over the party becoming a one-man show. 'Advani had observed Modi's style of functioning in Gujarat and was worried that he